

Three tiny, connected bones in the middle ear—the hammer, anvil, and stirrup—pass sound vibrations from the eardrum to the cochlea.

The semicircular canals help you balance.

Nerves

Nerve cells in the cochlea send messages about sounds to the brain.

The inner ear is made up of the cochlea and the semicircular canals. It is filled with liquid.

The eardrum is a thin sheet of skin that vibrates when sound waves hit it—just like the skin on a drum.

Hello . . . hello!

If you shout in a large, empty space, the sound waves from your voice bounce off the nearest surface, back to your ears. This is called an echo. The farther a sound has to travel before it is reflected, the longer you must wait for the echo.



Visible and invisible ears

Not all animals hear the same way you do. Some do not have any ears on the outside of their body.

Elephants have huge ear flaps and good hearing.

Birds and lizards have good hearing but no ear flaps on the sides of their heads.

A rabbit can turn its ears to hear sounds all around it.

